origin of the ‘sindur’ used by married Hindu women? All of these are intriguing thoughts but we cannot be absolutely sure that these had the same meaning for the Harappans.

In his recent book, Michel Danino has collected even more examples of continuity. We have already discussed the persistence of the ratio 5:4 in the previous chapter. We see the use of such ratios in many facets of Harappan life. They also had a standardized system of weights and measures, many of which are echoed two thousand years later in the *Arthashastra*, a manual on governance and political economy written in the third century BC. Danino calculates that the standard length used by the planners at Dholavira was 1.9 metres which is the same as the unit called *dhanush* (i.e. bow) used in the *Arthashastra*. He then shows that this unit was divided into 108 sub-units of 1.76 cm each. This fits with the 108 *angulas* (i.e. finger-widths) that made up a *dhanush*. [11] In fact, the old systems appear to have survived in a few places into the twentieth century. Till India switched a few decades ago to the metric system, the traditional weights and measures used in some parts of the subcontinent bore a striking resemblance to those used by the Harappan people. According to John Mitchiner, the difference was less than 1.8 per cent—not bad for a time lapse of over four thousand years!

Most interesting of all, chess pieces that look remarkably like modern equivalents have been found at Harappan sites. It has long been known that chess originated in India but it is extraordinary that the game, or something similar, was being played more than four thousand years ago. Even the famous town planning of the Harappans may have survived in later times. The streets of Kalibagan, a large site in Indian Punjab, are laid out with widths in a progression of 1.9 m, 3.8 m, 5.7 m and 7.6 m—the same as those prescribed in the *Arthashastra*. In short, the Harappans did not just disappear; they live on amongst us. They merged with the wider population and seeded what we now know as the Indian civilization. However, Indian civilization has parallel roots, in particular the Vedic tradition and its continuous history to this day. It is to this that we now turn.